United Kingdom Liaison Mission in Japan,
British Embassy,
TOKYO.

26th January, 1952.

CONFIDENTIAL
(1030/38/52)

FO.10310/41

Dear R.S.
F 10310/18

When I first saw Foreign Office telegram to Washington No. 449 of the 23rd January about Senator Sparkman's comments on the now notorious Yoshida letter, I almost thought that there were doubts in your mind as to whether or not the letter had been written under American pressure. I imagine, however, that what you want is quotable evidence of such pressure having been exercised. Unfortunately apart from Sparkman's incriminating statement I do not think this will be so easy to lay hands on. But in this letter I shall do my best to provide you with something at least.

The line taken by Japanese officials in conversation with members of my staff is that the letter was necessary in the view of the Japanese Government to ensure speedy and certain ratification of the Peace Treaty. The Vice Minister for Foreign Affairs for instance has produced a long story of how the Japanese Government finally came to their decision. The beginning was the letter sent about the time of the signature of the Treaty by a number of Republican Senators and Congress men to President Truman asking him to obtain from the Japanese Government a pledge not to recognise the Peking regime etc. Later the United States Government at the time of Dulles's visit, asked the Japanese Government to clarify their attitude on the question of the two Chinas. What in the end decided the Prime Minister however to send Mr. Dulles his famous letter was a report from the head of the Japanese Overseas Agency in Washington to the effect that, although it was possible that the Treaty would be ratified without a definite Japanese commitment to recognise Chiang Kai-shek, the task would be a difficult one.

As for the press and public statements, there has been practically no criticism of the actual commitment Yoshida has made except from the extreme Left. What he is criticised for is having done what he did without consulting his colleagues and without waiting for any opportunity for Diet discussion. Offhand I can only recall one instance where, in the responsible press, any reference at all has been made to American pressure. In the Diet, a new session of which has just opened, I understand that little criticism - and that guarded - is expected to be made of the contents of the letter, but that the attack will concentrate itself upon Yoshida's methods of conducting diplomacy.

Yet I doubt whether there is anyone here who does not know that the letter was in fact sent under American dictation. At the same time no one, except again on the extreme Left, seems to wish to admit it. The reason is simple. It is part of the Japanese defeat drill to acquiese in American wishes in order to secure the earliest possible end of the Occupation, and to

R.H. Scott, Esq., C.M.G., C.B.E.,

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Foreign Office.

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criticise Yoshida's decision, however humiliating or contrary to Japan's other interests it may be, would merely defeat the object of the exercise, and give Japan the worst of both worlds. Thus the Japanese public attitude provides no clue to Japanese feelings on the subject.

The best evidence available locally of American pressure is, of course, the suddenness of the decision to recognise Chian Kai-shek. As far as the Japanese are concerned it must seem to have happened overnight. Both before and during the visit of Dulles and the two Senators, there was, of course, ample evidence of pressure. Associated Press reported on the 17th December with a Taipeh date-line that Senator Owen Brewster, Maine Republican then visiting Formosa, said that it had been the understanding of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee that during negotiations of the Peace Treaty Japan had made a specific commitment to sign a separate peace with the Nationalists. When the two Senators visited the Diet it was reported (see my despatch No. 401 of the 31st December) that their forthright expressions of opinion about Japan's relations with the two Chinas came as a profound shock to some of the Diet men. Again on the 11th November when Mr. Dulles gave a press conference, the two Senators expressed strong hopes that Japan would execute a Peace Treaty with Nationalist China and Senator Sparkman warned that a very formidable road-block to Senate ratification would be created if Japan should show signs of recognising or opening trade relations with Communist China. No doubt also the two Senators in their private conferences with Japanese officials spoke similarly.

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Nevertheless I am convinced that the Prime Minister had not committed himself in any way at the time of Dulles's departure on December 20th. I would even go further and say that whatever the purported date of his letter, he did not make his decision until some time in January. I myself have not seen Yoshida since the night of the Japan-British Society's dinner on December 14th, but my Canadian colleague who saw him in January tells me that at that date Yoshida was still talking of China in the same terms as he had since he returned from San Francisco, namely of not committing himself politically to either China and of Japan acting as a "bridge" between the West and the Peoples' Republic, a line he really could hardly have taken had he at that time made his commitment to Chiang Kai-shek.

Exactly when and how the final pressure was applied I frankly do not know. It is however conceivable that it occurred on January 5th, a Saturday, when Yoshida was summoned from his sacrosanct weekend to see the Supreme Commander and my United States colleague at the Dai Ichi Building and was escorted to the rendez-vous by a military escort of jeeps. Despite my efforts I never discovered what was discussed at this meeting, but it is conceivable that it was an ultimatum on the China issue. It may also be that Yoshida's flat and rather complacent attitude towards Stalin's New Year message was what finally decided the United States Government that at least on China the Japanese Government should not be open to criticism in the Senate debates. This could also account for the pre-dating of the letter which might then not have been in existence at the time of the Secretary of State's conversation with Mr. Acheson on January 10th, which would of course absolve the Americans

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from any accusation of concealing from us so important a document.

We, of course, know that the Yoshida letter must have been issued at American dictation because of my interviews with Dulles in December. He made his intentions abundantly clear both by what he said and by the memorandum which he showed me. When we refused to change our attitude, he saw no reason to compromise on his requirements, and the Yoshida letter represents those requirements in full. I should estimate that the text of the letter was entirely composed by Dulles himself.

I am sending a copy of this letter to Washington.

Yours ever,

Bill Irwin

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